



THE BEST VERDICT on whether the Chinese threat is real or imagined

	VED MARWAH	SATISH NAMBIAR	BRAHMA CHELLANEY	AJIT KUMAR DOVAL	G. PARTHASARATHY	KAPIL KAK
What is China's Gameplan?	China has been following a policy of containing India, especially in the neighbourhood.	It has been uncomfortable with the Tibet policy but they may not go in for a military engagement.	China is trying to assert its territorial claims and its geo-political interests. It may resort to limited war.	It aims to leverage the differential between the powers of the two countries before India catches up.	China aims to dominate the balance of power in Asia. They may not keep their conflict peaceful.	It is seeking boundary concessions from India by aggressive intrusions on the Line of Actual Control.
What India Needs to do	A strategy is needed to check Chinese influence in the North-east as they can exploit our vulnerability.	We need to build on our cyber warfare capabilities as China has aggressively moved forward on this.	We should not take Chinese threats lightly. India needs to improve its strategic planning to match China's.	Don't create media hype but have an accelerated defence procurement policy with an eye on China.	India needs to widen its diplomatic options and should talk to China but not live in an illusion.	We need to harden our responses and actions like China as soft actions will not do much good.

Brahma Chellaney: They stepped up pressure along the frontier between 2007 and 2008. According to our Defence Ministry, the number of incursions virtually doubled, from 140 to 270. What we have seen till now shows that the spectre of a Sino-Indian cold war is looming large.

It is not just that, they saw the nuclear deal embedded in a larger strategic framework. We have played our cards badly, and we are left in the lurch. Americans in recent months have conveyed very discomfoting signals to India. They have made it clear that there will be no joint US-India military drill in Arunachal Pradesh and have told Delhi not to encourage the Dalai Lama to go to Arunachal Pradesh and Tawang. And you know when the President of the world's most powerful country chooses not to meet with the Dalai Lama, when he visits Washington D.C., it emboldens Beijing to step up pressure on the country that is providing a haven to him.

We are being squeezed from both sides. The American agenda now is to maintain good relations with Beijing, for them this relationship means a lot more—economically, politically and

strategically—than their relationship with India. I will not take these threats lightly. It seems they have presumed that the Indian leadership lacks political will and the military will not be able to resist a sharp-pointed thrust. For example, if they achieve a swift 1962 sort of victory then for next 30 to 40 years there will be no comparison between India and China. Because they have a lot of advantages, I would not minimise this danger.

Amitabh Mattoo: There is no question about the long-term competition, challenge and threat from China. But in an immediate sense, what India is seeing is really trivial incidents being exaggerated. So what we need to recognise is that there was certainly a turning point in terms of Indian proximity to the US and the nuclear deal where the Chinese thought that India would be used a counter-weight to them. And they would like to contain India to South Asia and have been using Pakistan time and time again as a way of ensuring that it remains confined. I think we need to not perpetuate hysteria, build our capacities, cooperate with the Chinese wherever possible and ensure that we don't have a crisis on

our hands. The possible dangers are that we could have a forward policy, we could be dragged into events or there could be a self-generating momentum which creates a 1962-like situation. We don't want that; not in 2009.

Aroon Purie: What does China want? Do they want territory or do they just want to keep India on the defensive? Why are these new tensions arising?

Nambiar: China has always been uncomfortable with India's Tibet policy. But in the past year they have developed a sense of insecurity with the uprising in Tibet and Xinjiang and with the labour unrest in its provinces.

So that is one aspect. The reason why I am bringing this up is that I believe that at the 60th anniversary parade, the paranoid security was something unimaginable. We have a great capacity for rhetoric as we are all taking this lightly because many things that have been happening for years, like the intrusion in Ladakh and Arunachal Pradesh, still continue.

Ved Marwah: The fact remains that China has been following a policy of containing India for years. But its presence in our neighbourhood has been felt a lot more over the recent years. It